

Formative Exercise: Marking Guide and Model Answer

IR227 Politics of Change: in-class formative, lecturer/TA reference

Friday 17 July 2026

Model answer and marking notes for the Country F formative, companion to the student sheet (formative-sheet). The exercise is ungraded; this guide supports the plenary debrief and the students' self-check. Budgets are tight: the formative gives about fifteen minutes across all three parts (bullets are fine), and the exam marks parts (a)–(c) at parity. The models below are fuller and more polished than a timed answer would be; treat them as the target shape, not a word count. Mark on three things: whether each framework part is attached to a named development in the scenario, whether part (b) reconstructs a mechanism rather than describing one, and whether part (c) weighs strengths and weaknesses for this case and points to how another framework resolves a gap, rather than voicing generic scepticism or launching a second framework analysis.

The scenario in brief

For more than a decade, Country F's plans to move its electricity system off imported gas and domestic coal went nowhere, blocked by the state power utility, coal-region legislators, and cautious energy ministers. Over a fourteen-month period five developments occurred: the national academy of engineering documented the country's high electricity prices and supply-shock exposure; a supplier dispute cut gas through a cold winter, causing rolling blackouts and a doubling of household bills; a general election returned a government dependent on a small green party, committed by its coalition agreement to an energy transition; a former grid-operator chief who had become a public figure during the blackouts was appointed energy-transition commissioner with a cross-ministry mandate; and a fully costed transition package (a binding renewables target, grid modernisation, a coal phase-out schedule, and an independent system operator), prepared years earlier and repeatedly shelved, sat ready in the energy-agency files. Within the year the government adopted the package over the objections of the utility and the coal-region legislators.

(a) Three streams

- **Problem stream.** The dependence on imported gas and domestic coal was a *condition* for years (in the world, but not demanding action) and became a *problem* only when two developments constructed it as one: the academy of engineering's analysis (high prices, supply-shock exposure) as an *indicator*, and the gas-cutoff winter of blackouts and doubled bills as the *focusing event* that made it urgent and public.
- **Policy stream.** The fully costed transition package in the energy-agency files (a binding renewables target, grid modernisation, a coal phase-out, an independent system operator), worked up years earlier and repeatedly shelved. It was ready to attach, not invented in response to the crisis.
- **Political stream.** All three of the political stream's elements appear: a change of government (the election returning a green-party-dependent coalition committed to transition), organised forces (the green party pushing, the utility and coal-region legislators resisting), and the shift in national mood the crisis produced (the "energy independence" framing).
- *Separates a strong answer:* each stream ends on a named development, and nothing is mis-sorted (the shelved package is policy-stream readiness, not a problem).

(b) Window and coupling

- **Window.** The decisive window was *unpredictable*: the energy crisis of gas cutoff, blackouts, and bill spike, the kind that rewards whoever is prepared rather than whoever caused it. The election is best read either as a change of government inside the political stream or as a second, *predictable* window, with the entrepreneur exploiting the overlap.
- **Coupling.** The commissioner joined the ready package to the newly urgent problem under a receptive government, reframing it as energy independence rather than climate. Coupling is the action that connected the streams; without it the package stays shelved.
- **Entrepreneur.** The commissioner, a *personal* entrepreneur in Lecture 2's typology (an identifiable individual), identified by her investment of *her own* resources: reputation (she staked her position) and time and energy (brokering the coalition's energy

chapter and campaigning for it). The cross-ministry mandate is enabling access, not a resource she risked. The academy and the media fed the problem stream but coupled nothing.

- *Separates a strong answer:* the window is typed, coupling is an action rather than a coincidence, and the entrepreneur is identified through investment rather than prominence.

(c) *Evaluation*

- **Strengths.** MSF explains the *timing* well: a decade-blocked reform passed once a ready solution, an urgent problem, and a receptive government aligned. It also fits the case's inversion of the usual order, the transition package having pre-dated the crisis by years and waited in the files, which is what the policy stream predicts.
- **Weaknesses, on this case.** MSF is light on power: it registers that the window opened but not what let the utility and coal bloc block reform for a decade, nor what finally broke their hold. It also under-specifies selection: it establishes that a solution was ready, not why the stringent version (a binding target, an independent system operator) was adopted rather than a softer scheme.
- **Resolving the gaps, by reference.** Each weakness points to a framework a fuller analysis would turn to: the power gap to Punctuated Equilibrium Theory (the incumbents' policy monopoly, broken by the crisis and a venue shift, Lecture 3) or to Lecture 5's veto players; the selection gap to the Advocacy Coalition Framework (coalition beliefs and policy-oriented learning, Lecture 3). These are referenced as the direction of resolution, not developed into a second framework analysis given space constraints.
- *Separates a strong answer:* strengths and weaknesses genuinely weighed for *this* case, with resolving frameworks referenced rather than developed due to the space constraints. The key is to not engage in generic (non-case specific) scepticism.

Closing the loop to the assessments

The final exam asks for the same three moves at greater depth: about 60 minutes and 800 words per question, in full prose, answering two questions across the paper. The mid-term take-home essay uses the same analytical move on a case of the student's choosing; the

one added expectation there is that they ground the analysis in the research literature and reference it, which the exam does not require.